

5.4.2 Area of Study 2 - Techniques of Melodic Composition

Starting Point

Pitch as the raw material of melody and its use as a means of expression. Different organisations of pitch from a range of times and cultures, exemplified in:

- folk music of the British Isles (modal and pentatonic scales);
- plainchant (modes);
- Indian Classical music (*raga*);
- the mainstream Western tradition (major and minor scales);
- twentieth century innovations (whole-tone scale, serialism, blues scale, microtonality).

Candidates should learn the connection between the organisation of pitch and the compositional processes which are used in the specified traditions:

- the oral tradition of folk music which leads naturally to modal and pentatonic tunes
- the given procedures of plainsong
- the musical procedures and patterns in Indian Classical music
- the harmonic processes used in Western Classical music and the exploitation of new harmonies through the development of whole tone music
- the process of using a twelve note row in serial music
- the alteration of notes of the scale in blues improvisation for particular effect.

Contextual understanding should be developed through exploring how the different musical purposes, venues and intended effect on the different 'audiences' influences the way music is created, performed and heard within each of the specified traditions.

Core

Candidates should develop aural perception and musical knowledge of the principal techniques of melody-writing exemplified specifically in the music of the mainstream Baroque and Classical periods (c1700 - 1830), drawing on both vocal and instrumental genres, with a particular focus on:

- the simpler forms of the periods (binary, ternary, rondo, variation), using modulation and contrast to sustain the structures;
- diatonic intervals and their expressive qualities in the construction of melodic phrases;
- common devices for balancing, extending or varying phrases (as listed in the Language for Learning);
- techniques of ornamenting simple melodies.

Candidates should be taught how composers use these features in combination to create effective melodies. They should learn how to create melodies drawing on these features and be taught how to articulate them either by using an instrument, ICT or using staff notation.

Links

Area of Study 1: candidates should be encouraged to apply knowledge gained here to enhance their understanding of their own instrument (or voice) as a suitable vehicle either for a melodic line or in a supporting role (*Exploiting the Resource*).

Area of Study 3: opportunities should be made for candidates to explore the relationships between melody and rhythmic patterns in contrasting dances from the different periods (*Dance Music*).

Area of Study 4: opportunities can be made for the study of contrasting melodic characteristics in music drawn from a wider range of cultures, and for exploring the impact of non-Western rhythmic traditions (*Traditions and Innovation*).

Language for Learning

Candidates should be taught to understand, recognise aurally, and correctly use the following terminology which describes features which arise specifically within the content of this Area of Study:

- Plainchant, *rag*, folksong, serialism, blues;
- Scales: mode (modal), pentatonic, major, minor, *raga*, tone-row, whole-tone, blue-note, microtone;
- Phrase/phrasing: anacrusis, answering phrase, question and answer, perfect, plagal, interrupted and imperfect cadences;
- Modulation: tonic, dominant, relative minor/major;
- Forms: binary, ternary, rondo, variation, the convention of describing melodic structures such as AABA, AABC, ABAC, *da capo*, *coda*, verse, chorus;
- Intervals: 2nd, 3rd, 4th, 5th, 6th, 7th, octave, unison, tone, semitone;
- Devices: repetition, inversion, ascending/descending sequence, motive, retrograde, imitation;
- Ornamentation: passing-note, trill, turn, grace-note.

It is expected that, through this, candidates will become familiar with the use of words associated with the resources used in the musical examples they study and that, as a minimum, candidates will be familiar with:

- the names of different types of voice (soprano, contralto, tenor, bass);
- the names of typical Baroque and Classical ensembles and their characteristic features (orchestra, string quartet, continuo, choir);
- the names of other resources commonly used in the styles defined in the Starting Point (*sitar* and *tabla*, jazz band).

The names of the composers of the music studied should also be known.